

reading blogs.)

11) Spending energy on the difference between ontic and epistemic randomness—true randomness, and randomness that arises from incomplete information—instead of focusing on the more consequential difference between Mediocristan and Extremistan. (People with no hobby, no personal problems, no love, and too much free time.)

12) Thinking I am saying “Do not forecast” or “Do not use models,” rather than “Do not use sterile forecasts with huge error” and “Do not use models in the Fourth Quadrant.” (Mistake made by most people who forecast for a living.)

13) Mistaking what I say for “S**t happens” rather than “this is where s**t happens.” (Many former bonus earners.)^{*}

Indeed, the intelligent, curious, and open-minded amateur is my friend. A pleasant surprise for me was to discover that the sophisticated amateur who uses books for his own edification, and the journalist (unless, of course, he was employed by *The New York Times*), could understand my idea much better than professionals. Professional readers, less genuine, either read too quickly or have an agenda. When reading for “work” or for the purpose of establishing their status (say, to write a review), rather than to satisfy a genuine curiosity, readers who have too much baggage (or perhaps not enough) tend to read rapidly and efficiently, scanning jargon terms and rapidly making associations with prepackaged ideas. This resulted early on in the squeezing of the ideas expressed in *The Black Swan* into a commoditized well-known framework, as if my positions could be squeezed into standard skepticism, empiricism, essentialism, pragmatism, Popperian falsificationism, Knightian uncertainty, behavioral economics, power laws, chaos theory, etc. But the amateurs saved my ideas. Thank you, reader.

As I wrote, missing a train is only painful if you are running after it. I was not looking to have a bestseller (I thought I had already had one with my previous book, and just wanted to produce a real thing), so I had to deal with a spate of harrying side effects. I watched as the book was initially treated, owing to its bestseller status, like the nonfiction “idea books,” journalistic through and through, castrated by a thorough and “competent” copy editor, and sold in airports to “thinking” businessmen. Giving these enlightened *Bildungsphilisters*, commonly called idea-book readers, a real book is like giving vintage Bordeaux to drinkers of Diet Coke and listening to their comments about it. Their typical complaint is